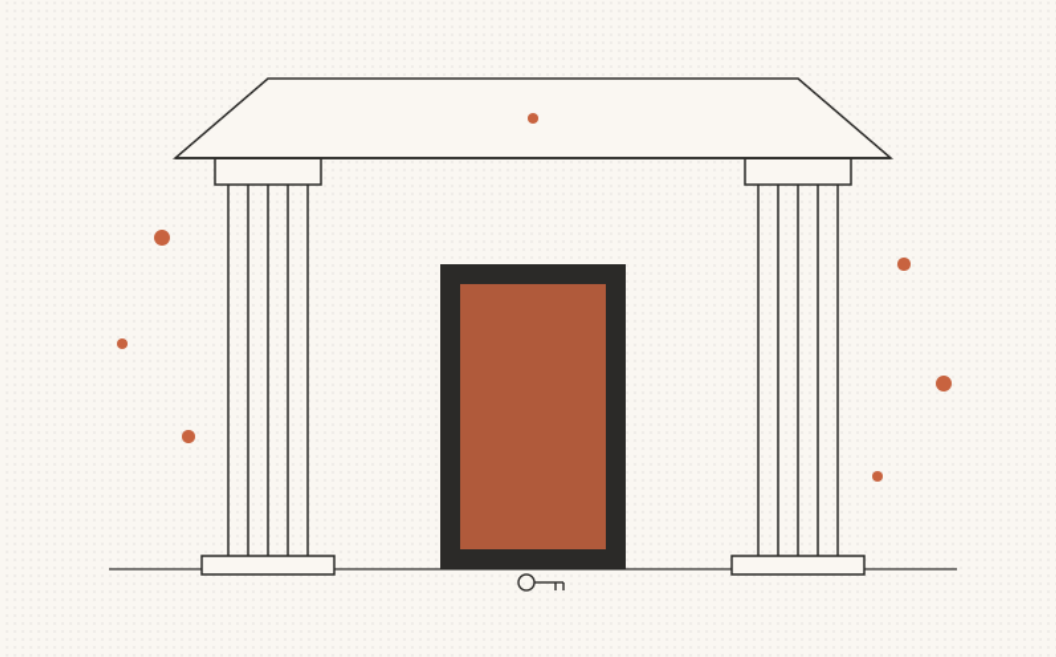


A LECTURE FROM COAST

The Memory Palace

an ancient craft you can use tonight

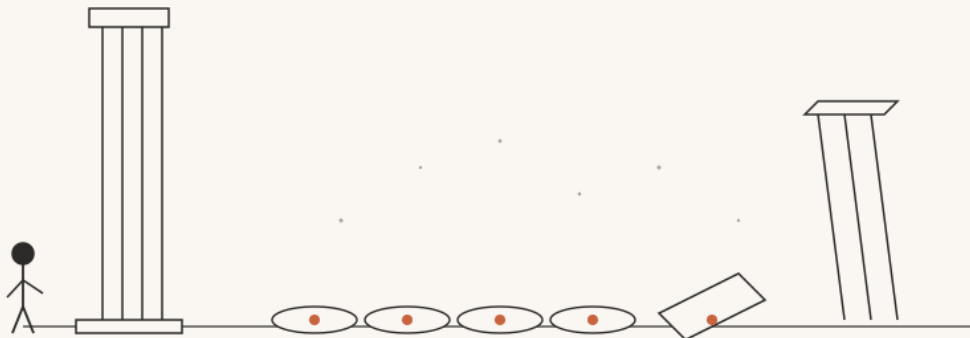


How a Greek poet, a collapsing roof, and your childhood bedroom can teach you to remember almost anything.

A story from 2,500 years ago

In the year 477 BC, a Greek poet named Simonides of Ceos was hired to perform at a banquet in Thessaly. He recited his poem, was paid, and stepped outside for a moment. While he was out, the roof of the banquet hall collapsed. Everyone inside was killed, and the bodies were crushed beyond recognition — so badly that the families could not tell who was who in order to bury them.

Simonides closed his eyes. And he found that he could remember exactly where each guest had been sitting. He walked the grieving families around the ruins, pointing: *your son was here, your husband was there.*



Simonides surveys the ruin. Each marker is a seat he can still place from memory.

That night, he realised something. He had not *tried* to memorise the seating chart. He simply had it. His mind, it seemed, was extraordinarily good at remembering places — even when it was terrible at remembering almost everything else.

Out of that horror, he invented a technique. He realised that if your brain naturally remembers locations, you can *smuggle* other information into your memory by attaching it to locations you already know. Want to remember a speech? Break it into pieces and place each piece in a room of your house. Walk through the house in your mind, and the speech comes back.

For the next two thousand years, this was how educated humans remembered things. Roman senators used it for hour-long speeches with no notes. Medieval monks used it to memorise entire books of scripture. It has a name: the **method of loci**, or, more poetically, the **memory palace**.

And then we invented paper, and printing, and phones, and we mostly forgot it existed.

This lecture is going to give it back to you.

A small demonstration

Before I explain anything else, I want to prove something to you. I want you to memorise this list, in order:

1. Banana
2. Telescope
3. Toothbrush
4. Elephant
5. Candle
6. Skateboard
7. Pineapple
8. Violin
9. Lightbulb
10. Astronaut

Do not try yet. Just read it.

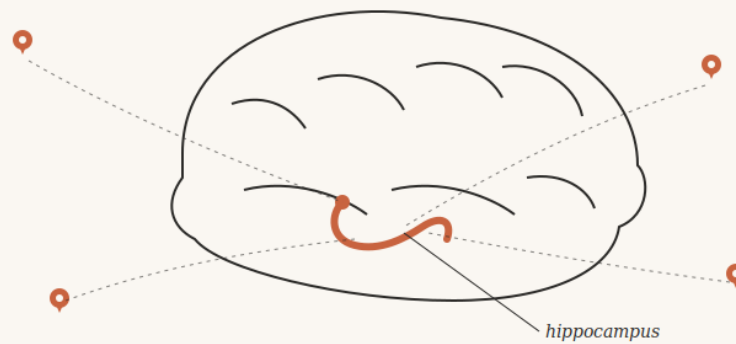
If I asked you to recall it in thirty seconds, you would probably get five or six. If I asked you tomorrow, you would get two or three if you were lucky. This is normal. Human working memory holds about seven items, and they slip fast.

By the end of this lecture, you will remember this list — in order, forwards and backwards — and you will still remember it a week from now without rehearsing. Not because you are clever. Because the technique is that powerful.

Why your brain is built this way

Here is the mechanism, and it is worth understanding before we use it.

Evolution did not design human memory to hold shopping lists or vocabulary. It designed it to keep you alive in a physical environment. *Where is the water? Where did the predator come from last time? Which berry made my cousin sick, and where was that bush?* The brain has dedicated hardware for spatial memory — the hippocampus, your entorhinal cortex, your place cells and grid cells. It is astonishingly powerful and runs almost without effort.



The hippocampus: small, ancient, and the most powerful piece of memory hardware you own.

Semantic memory — the kind you use for abstract facts, names, dates — runs on much weaker hardware. Trying to memorise a list of words with raw willpower is like trying to lift a car. Trying to memorise them by placing them in a room you grew up in is like using a forklift. The forklift was always there; you just were not using it.

The memory palace is a forklift.

“Think of your childhood bedroom. Can you walk through it in your mind right now? Where was the bed? The window? The door? You probably haven’t been there in years, but the map is intact. That is the hardware we are about to use.”

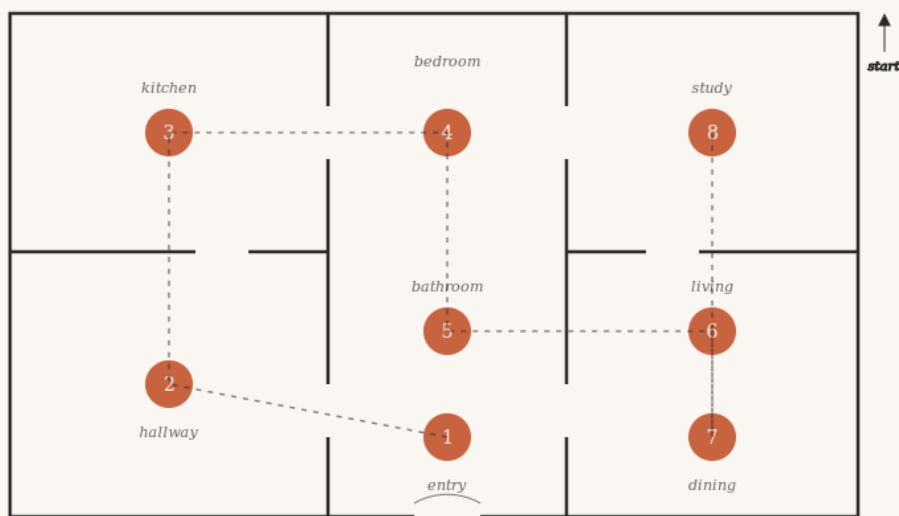
Module 4

Building your first palace

Pick a place you know extremely well. Not a place you have visited — a place you have *lived*. Most people use a childhood home, their current apartment, or the route from their front door to their kitchen. We will keep it small for now: pick **five locations** along a path through this place. They should be in a fixed order — front door, hallway, kitchen, living room, bedroom, for example.

Take thirty seconds and decide on yours. Write the five locations down.

Done? Good. That is your palace. It will work for the rest of your life.



An example palace with eight stations. The dashed line is the route you always walk in the same order.

Module 5

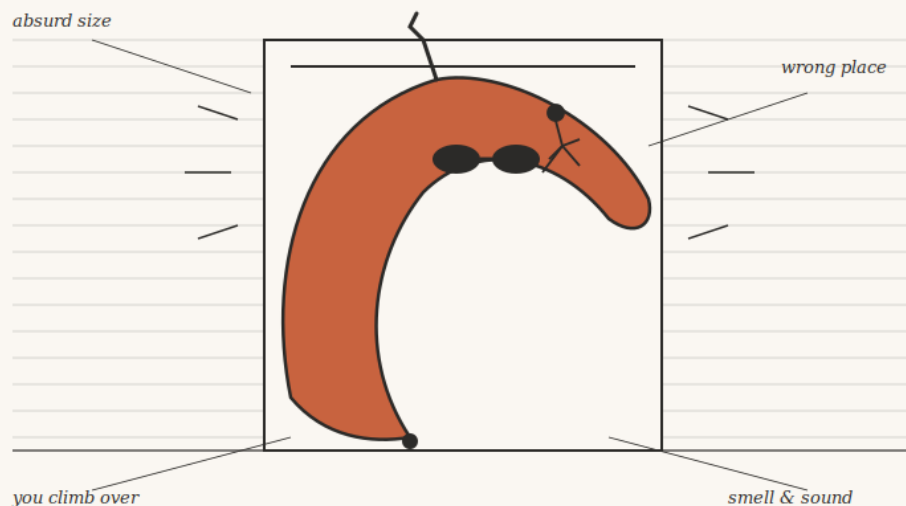
The encoding rule (this is the secret)

Here is the part that most people get wrong on their first try.

If I told you to place ‘banana’ in your front hallway, you might picture a banana sitting on the floor. That will not work. Your brain will not remember a banana sitting on a floor, because there is nothing about it worth remembering.

The rule is: **make it weird, vivid, and impossible to ignore.**

Do not put a banana in your hallway. Put a *giant, slipping, screaming banana the size of a refrigerator, wearing sunglasses, blocking the front door so you have to climb over it*. Smell it. Hear the squelch. Feel yourself climbing.



The wrong way: a banana on the floor. The right way: this.

This sounds ridiculous. It is ridiculous. That is exactly why it works. Your brain ignores normal things and clings to absurd, emotional, multisensory things. There is a name for this — the **von Restorff effect** — but you do not need the term. You just need to remember that boring placements fail, and theatrical ones stick.

Three rules for good encoding:

1. **Make it absurd.** Wrong size, wrong place, wrong behaviour.
2. **Make it sensory.** Smell, sound, texture — not just a picture.
3. **Put yourself in the scene.** Interact with the object. The brain remembers things that happened to *you* far better than things you observed.

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Module 6

Exercise — place the first five

Take your palace. Take the first five items from our list. Place them, one per location, using the encoding rules above. Do not rush. Spend about fifteen seconds on each.

1. **Banana** — in location 1
2. **Telescope** — in location 2
3. **Toothbrush** — in location 3
4. **Elephant** — in location 4
5. **Candle** — in location 5

Build each scene fully before moving on. Do not just label the location with the word — see the banana, hear the elephant, watch the candle.

When you are done, close your eyes and walk the path. The items should come back in order, almost effortlessly. If one is fuzzy, go back and make it weirder.

Module 7

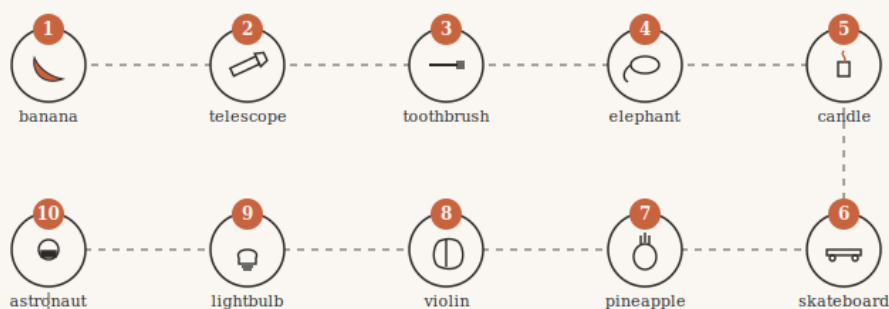
Scaling up

Now add five more locations to your palace — locations six through ten. Place the remaining items:

- 6. **Skateboard** — in location 6
- 7. **Pineapple** — in location 7
- 8. **Violin** — in location 8
- 9. **Lightbulb** — in location 9
- 10. **Astronaut** — in location 10

Walk the full palace once. Then walk it backwards — astronaut, lightbulb, violin, all the way back to the banana. You will find you can. This is the moment most learners realise the technique is real.

the walk: ten items, ten rooms



*Walk the path once forward, once backward.
The order is not held in the list — it is held in the route through your home.*

Checkpoint. Without flipping back, what was item number seven? What was item number three? What item was in your second location?

If you got these right, you just outperformed the version of yourself that read this list ten minutes ago by a wide margin — using a technique you didn't know existed an hour ago.

How far this goes

The world memory champions — and they exist, there is an actual competition — use exactly this technique. They memorise the order of a shuffled deck of cards in under twenty seconds. They memorise hundreds of digits, thousands of binary numbers, hours of poetry. They are not born with special brains. Brain scans show their hippocampi are slightly larger than average, but only because they trained them. They use palaces with hundreds of locations, often combining each spot with a **PAO system** — Person, Action, Object — so a single location can hold three pieces of information at once.

You will probably not become a memory champion, and you do not need to. But the ceiling is much higher than you think. A motivated student can build a palace large enough to hold an entire anatomy course, the periodic table, every important date in a history syllabus, or the vocabulary of a foreign language at conversational level.

How to use this for actual studying

Lists of objects are the training wheels. Real studying involves abstract concepts, and the palace handles those too — you just need to translate the abstraction into something physical before placing it.

- ◆ **Vocabulary (language learning).** Put a visual pun for the word in the location. The Spanish word *caballo* (horse) sounds like ‘cab-eye-oh’ — picture a horse driving a taxi cab through your kitchen.
- ◆ **Dates and numbers.** Assign each digit 0–9 a consonant sound (the **Major System** — worth a future lecture), turn numbers into words, and place the words.
- ◆ **Lists of concepts.** Turn each concept into a symbol. The cardiovascular system in your bathroom: heart in the sink, arteries running through the showerhead.
- ◆ **Speeches and arguments.** Place each main point in a location, with a vivid symbol that triggers the next sentence.

The technique is old, but it is not obsolete. It is, in fact, almost completely unused by modern students, which means knowing it is a quiet competitive advantage that costs you nothing.

A closing thought

For most of human history, before books were cheap and before phones existed, every piece of knowledge you wanted to keep had to live inside your skull. The people who built our civilisations — the poets, the lawyers, the priests, the philosophers — held entire libraries in their heads. They did not have better brains than you. They had a better technique, and they treated memory as a craft.

We outsourced memory to paper, and then to silicon, and we gained a lot. But we also lost something. There is a particular kind of intimacy with knowledge that only comes from holding it inside you, where you can walk around it.

Tonight, before you sleep, walk through your palace one more time. See if the astronaut is still in the last room.

He will be.

Welcome back to a two-and-a-half-thousand-year-old craft.



What to learn next on Coast

- ◆ *The Major System* — turning numbers into images.
- ◆ *PAO and beyond* — what the memory athletes actually do.
- ◆ *Building a palace for a real exam* — applied workshop with Pedro.